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Exterior DIY Repair Plan

Property: 757 Santa Ray Avenue, Oakland, CA 94610

Total Estimated Cost: \$200 - \$600

Priority:  Medium Priority

Skill Level: Beginner

Summary of DIY Exterior Repairs

Priority	Issue	Location	Est. Cost	Difficulty
 MEDIUM	Reconnect Loose Downspout	Right rear	\$10-20	Easy
 MEDIUM	Repair Exterior Stucco Cracks	Multiple locations	\$20-40	Easy
 MEDIUM	Secure Loose Exterior Light Fixture	Front entrance	\$5-10	Easy

 **DIY OPPORTUNITY:** These are straightforward repairs that require basic tools and materials, preventing larger issues and saving hundreds in handyman costs.

MEDIUM PRIORITY

1. Reconnect Loose Downspout

- **Goal:** Securely re-attach the downspout at the right rear of the house to the underground drain line.
- **Tools & Materials:**
 - Ladder
 - Drill or screwdriver
 - New downspout straps/brackets (if needed)
 - Rust-proof screws (1-inch self-tapping screws work well)
 - Pliers

Step-by-Step Instructions:

1. **Inspect the Area:** Carefully examine why the downspout is loose. Are the existing straps broken, or are the screws stripped or missing? Check the connection point at the gutter and at the ground drain.
2. **Align the Downspout:** Position the downspout so it sits correctly under the gutter outlet and aligns with the drainpipe at the bottom.
3. **Secure to Wall:**
 - If the old screw holes are intact, use slightly larger screws for a tighter fit.
 - If new holes are needed, hold a new strap in place and use a drill to fasten it to the wall with self-tapping screws.
 - Use at least two straps: one near the top and one near the bottom, to hold it firmly against the wall.

4. **Connect to Drain:** Ensure the bottom of the downspout is securely fitted inside the underground drain opening to direct water away from the foundation.
5. **Test It:** Use a garden hose to run water down the gutter and through the downspout to confirm it flows correctly without leaks.

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2. Repair Exterior Stucco Cracks

- **Goal:** Seal small cracks in the exterior stucco to prevent moisture intrusion.
- **Tools & Materials:**
 - Wire brush
 - Putty knife
 - Caulking gun
 - Paintable, exterior-grade elastomeric or masonry caulk
 - Safety glasses

Step-by-Step Instructions:

1. **Clean the Cracks:** Use a wire brush to vigorously scrub out any loose debris, dirt, or paint from inside and around the cracks. The surface must be clean and dry for the caulk to adhere properly.
2. **Apply Caulk:** Cut the tip of the caulk tube at a 45-degree angle to create a small opening. Apply a steady, continuous bead of caulk directly into the crack.
3. **Smooth the Seam:** Immediately after applying, use a putty knife or a gloved finger to press the caulk firmly into the crack and smooth the surface. Feather the edges to blend the repair with the existing stucco texture.
4. **Cure:** Let the caulk cure completely as per the manufacturer's instructions (typically 24 hours).
5. **Paint (Optional):** Once fully cured, you can paint over the repair to match the rest of the wall, which will also add another layer of protection.

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3. Secure Loose Exterior Light Fixture

- **Goal:** Firmly attach the light fixture to the wall to prevent movement and potential electrical issues.
- **Tools & Materials:**
 - Screwdriver (likely Phillips head)
 - Voltage tester (recommended for safety)
 - Ladder

Step-by-Step Instructions:

1. **SAFETY FIRST - Turn Off Power:** Go to your home's main electrical panel and switch off the circuit breaker that controls the front entrance light.
2. **Confirm Power is Off:** Flick the light switch on and off to ensure it doesn't turn on. For extra safety, use a voltage tester on the wires inside the fixture before touching them.

3. **Inspect the Fixture:** Identify what is loose. Usually, it's the two decorative nuts or screws on the outside of the fixture's base.
4. **Tighten the Fixture:** Use a screwdriver to tighten these screws. Turn them clockwise until the fixture base is snug and flush against the wall. Do not overtighten, as you could crack the base.
5. **Check the Mounting Bracket (if still loose):** If tightening the outer screws doesn't work, the internal mounting bracket may be loose.
 - Unscrew the outer screws completely and gently pull the fixture away from the wall.
 - Tighten the screws that hold the metal mounting bracket to the electrical junction box in the wall.
 - Re-install the fixture.
6. **Restore Power:** Turn the circuit breaker back on and test the light.

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